



Soviet SAM

SA-2 surface-to-air missiles (SAMs) were supplied to the North Vietnamese. The USSR also provided technicians and trainers to operate these advanced missile systems, which were highly effective against enemy aircraft.

Northern resilience

Traffic along the Ho Chi Minh Trail proved an elusive target. Indeed, North Vietnamese infiltration of South Vietnam accelerated in spite of the bombing. US intelligence estimated that there were fewer than 100 viable military targets in the whole of North Vietnam prior to Rolling Thunder, and virtually all of those targets were damaged or destroyed by 1966. The people of North Vietnam, a largely nonindustrialized country, simply found ways of adapting to the destruction that surrounded them.

North Vietnamese air defenses consisted of Soviet-made fighter aircraft, radar, anti-aircraft artillery, and surface-to-air missile sites, but also a highly organized civil defense program. With air raid sirens, frequent drills, and extensive underground shelters, North Vietnamese civilians soon learned to clear busy streets and squares in a matter of seconds, further limiting the human cost of the bombing.